Rumor Control and Verifying Emergency Information

Pause before you pass along an emergency claim. Find the original message, check it against a current official source, and share only what people need to act safely.

! WARNING — URGENT ACTION

Do not let verification delay protective action. If a current official alert tells you to evacuate, shelter, or avoid an area, follow it immediately. Call 911 for immediate danger. Do not wait for a neighbor, group chat, or social-media post to agree.

USE THE SIFT CHECK

1. **Stop.** Do not react to a headline, screenshot, cropped video, forwarded voice message, or urgent request to “share with everyone.” Ask: What exact claim would I be repeating?
2. **Identify the source.** Find the person or organization that first published the claim. A familiar sender is not necessarily the original source.
3. **Find official coverage.** Check the responsible public agency's website, verified account, alert, or recorded information line. When safety and time allow, confirm through a second official source.
4. **Trace the context.** Open the original message. Check its issue time, location, map boundaries, links, and whether a newer official update replaced it.

Warning signs

- No issuing agency, date, time, or location
- A screenshot with no link to the original
- A look-alike account or misspelled web address
- An old photo, map, or alert presented as current
- A claim that only unnamed insiders can confirm
- Pressure to forward before checking

Stronger evidence

- The original, current agency message
- A known official web address opened directly
- The same instruction on another official channel
- A clearly marked issue time and affected area
- A correction or update from the issuing agency
- Information that still matches the latest alert

SHARE WITHOUT ADDING CONFUSION

Use plain attribution: **“At [time], [agency] said [instruction] for [location]. Check [official source] for updates.”** Link to the original when possible. Do not crop away the issuer, date, map legend, or safety instructions. Do not guess why an alert was sent, declare an area safe, or turn an observation into an official instruction.

Rumor Control and Verifying Emergency Information — continued

WHEN A CLAIM IS NOT CONFIRMED

1. **Do not amplify it.** Repeating a false claim—even to criticize it—can spread it farther.
2. **Save and route it.** Note the exact claim, source, and timestamp without reposting it. Match the topic to the responsible agency: incident instructions, roads, utilities, schools, or public health.
3. **Ask safely.** Use the agency's published non-emergency contact or rumor-reporting channel. Keep 911 free for immediate threats to life or property.
4. **Correct with evidence.** Share the current official information and link. Avoid shaming the person who sent the claim.
5. **Update the same audience.** If you shared information that became wrong or outdated, clearly correct it wherever you posted it.

QUICK VERIFICATION RECORD

Check	What I found
Exact claim	_____
Original source / link	_____
Issue time, update time, and place	_____
Responsible agency / source checked	_____
Result	☐ Confirmed ☐ False ☐ Outdated ☐ Unconfirmed

◎ LOCAL INFORMATION — VERIFY BEFORE APPROVAL

COMPLETE ONLY AFTER LOCAL VERIFICATION

Emergency authority / alerts page: _____
Official non-emergency information line: _____
Rumor-control page, if provided: _____
Verified by / date: _____ / _____

PROTECT PEOPLE WHILE CHECKING

- ☐ Keep names, home addresses, medical details, and absence information private.
- ☐ Do not call a number or open a link supplied only in the questionable message.
- ☐ Do not travel into a closed or dangerous area to confirm a report.
- ☐ Label firsthand observations clearly, and keep checking as conditions change.

SOURCES

Sources: FEMA, “Rumor Response”; Ready.gov, “Alerts and Warnings.” Accessed September 25, 2026.